Burnes was devastated. All his views had been ignored, and all his work destroyed. As Masson later reported, for a while Burnes ‘abandoned himself to despair. He bound his head with wet towels and handkerchiefs, and took to the smelling bottle. It was humiliating to witness such an exhibition, and the ridicule to which it gave rise.’[95] But over the weeks which followed Burnes recovered and fought a brave rearguard action, pushing at the boundaries of his instructions to see if there was a loophole with which he could keep Vitkevitch at bay.

He worked with the more pro-British nobles to see if Dost Mohammad could be persuaded to accept merely a promise of British protection. He also seems to have thrown money around, in an attempt to gather support, something that is mentioned in all the Afghan sources. ‘Burnes started meeting secretly with the great nobles and chiefs of Kabul,’ remembered Mirza ‘Ata, ‘all of whom had one great love, a love of money and the clink-clink of gold coins – so he soon perverted them and bought their support with bribes.’[96] But the conclusion was still inevitable. Intermediaries, including Nawab Jabar Khan, Dost Mohammad’s Anglophile brother who had sent his son to be educated by Wade in Ludhiana, attempted to bring the two sides together, but the insulting and patronising tone of Auckland’s letter, as much as its actual contents, had made a compromise impossible. As the Amir observed, the one thing he could never abandon was his *izzat* – his honour. ‘It was Auckland who had abandoned the Afghans,’ he told Burnes, ‘and not he who had deserted the British.’[97]

Events at Herat strengthened Russia’s hand, even as the British were undermining their own position. The siege of the town was tightening its grip. Eldred Pottinger wrote to Burnes reporting that:

> The country is utterly and totally ruined for the next year, there is neither seed to sow or cattle to sow it if there were. I really fear that the unfortunate Shiahs [within the town] will be sold into slavery in a mass . . . In the city there is great distress as few calculated the siege lasting more than a few weeks . . . Sheep have become almost unknown in the city and the supply of water being stopped, the public reservoirs and cisterns have become nearly too foul to use.[98]

Moreover, Count Simonitch had now arrived in the Shah’s camp and was playing an increasingly active role in directing the siege operations. As MacNeill reported, ‘The evidence of concert between Persia and Russia, for purposes injurious to British interests, is unequivocal and the magnitude of the evil with which we are threatened is, in my estimation, immense.’[99]